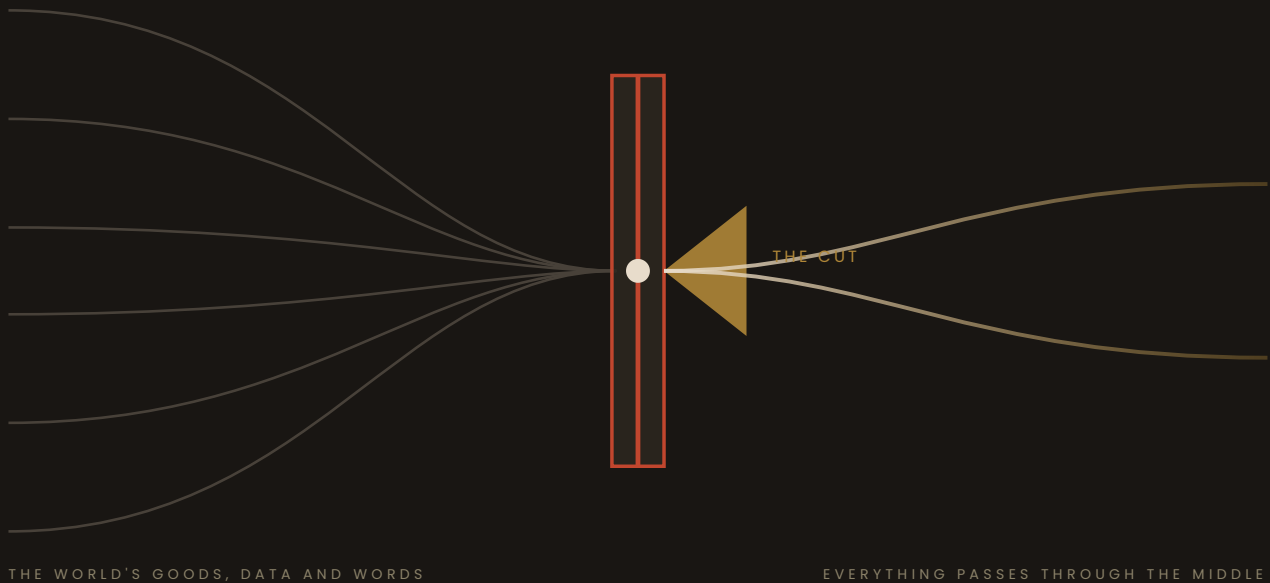


THE CURRENT BRIEFING OF

MERIDIAN

Twelve desks. One world.



THE WORLD

The Gulf war widens onto a second sea lane: Houthi gunners hit two Saudi tankers, Brent tops \$94, and a ten-day truce offer goes unanswered

TECHNOLOGY

The AI-spending bill comes due — TSMC banks a record quarter while Google's own capex stings its stock

SINGAPORE

Wong remakes the Cabinet and renames a ministry as the next-generation succession quietly accelerates

THIS ISSUE

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p21–23 The Long Read — “The Middleman’s Hour”

FROM THE DESK

“As soon as the land of any country has all become private property, the landlords, like all other men, love to reap where they never sowed.”

— **Adam Smith, *An Inquiry into the Nature and Causes of the Wealth of Nations*, Book I (1776)¹**

Smith was describing rent — the charge for standing between a thing and the person who wants it. The issue is full of the practice: a movement that holds a strait taxes the world’s oil without pumping a barrel (p3); a foundry banked a record quarter while the firms it supplies were punished for spending (p7); a chatbot now writes the charm between two strangers on a dating app (p17). The Long Read (p21) follows the middleman from Venice to the toll-castles of the Rhine, and asks the only question that ever mattered about the layer in the middle: does it add something, or just hold the gate?

BRENT CRUDE

~\$94.1 ▲

GOLD (XAU)

\$4,138 ▲

BITCOIN

~\$65.9k ▼

USD/SGD

~1.29

US 10-YEAR

4.64% ▲

THE WEEK AT A GLANCE

Widened: the Gulf war reached a second chokepoint — Houthi forces struck two Saudi tankers and five more diverted from the Bab el-Mandeb, driving Brent above \$94 (p3).

Banked: TSMC posted a record quarter as HPC hit two-thirds of wafer revenue, even as Alphabet’s own capex guidance knocked its shares (p7).

Reshuffled: PM Wong promoted first-term MPs to full minister and renamed the trade ministry, effective 1 October (p5); and July’s Fed meeting turned into a live call on a hike, not a hold (p15).

STANDING NOTE

Issue No. 50 runs as a straight weekday news book — no single motif is forced across the twelve desks. Only the Long Read (p21) argues one connected idea, and it earns it from the week rather than imposing it: the recurring figure this fortnight is the intermediary — the party that stands in the middle of a flow and takes a cut.

SOURCES ¹ Adam Smith, *The Wealth of Nations*, Book I, ch. 6 & 11 (1776). Market strip: TradingEconomics, Fortune, CNBC, StockAnalysis.com — levels as of 21–22 Jul 2026, subject to change by press time; USD/SGD held near its early-July print (~1.29) rather than guessed at an unverified fresher figure; VWRA’s 21 Jul print (\$188.46) is carried on p15.

THE WORLD · THE GULF WAR, DAY 30

The War Finds Its Second Strait

A blockade declared last weekend hardened this week into gunfire on tankers, as the Gulf war spread from Hormuz to the Bab el-Mandeb — and a ten-day ceasefire offer sat, unanswered, on two desks at once.

The Houthis' declared blockade of Saudi Arabia stopped being a threat and became a fact this week. The Yemeni movement said it carried out an operation against two Saudi crude tankers — named in its statement as the *Encela* and the *Laylia* — for "violating" the blockade of the Bab el-Mandeb, the twenty-kilometre neck between the Red Sea and the Gulf of Aden through which roughly a tenth of world trade physically passes.¹ After two Saudi-bound tankers turned back on Tuesday, five more changed course on Wednesday to avoid the strait, compounding a squeeze already gripping the Strait of Hormuz, where the cargo-tracking firm Kpler recorded transit traffic falling for a second straight day.²

The main war did not pause to make room for the new front. US Central Command concluded its eleventh consecutive night of strikes on Iran at 00:15 GMT on Wednesday, hitting operations centres, maritime capabilities, aircraft hangars and drone-storage sites, after Kuwait's army intercepted Iranian drones crossing its airspace.³ President Trump sharpened his terms, vowing to "bomb and destroy one bridge or power plant" in Iran for every ship fired on in Hormuz; Iran's foreign ministry called the threat to civilian infrastructure a war crime and named interference in the strait an "unbreakable red line."⁴

~10%

OF WORLD TRADE PASSES THROUGH THE BAB EL-MANDEB THE HOUTHIS ARE NOW FIRING ON — THE SECOND CHOKEPOINT THIS WAR KEEPS RETURNING TO, AFTER HORMUZ.

Markets read the widening the way they always read a strait — on the fear, not the fact. Brent jumped about 4% on 22 July to close near \$94.83, its highest in roughly six weeks, with two of the world's essential oil corridors under simultaneous threat.⁵ And yet a way out is on the table: mediators from Qatar, Egypt and Pakistan have floated a ten-day ceasefire under which both Hormuz lanes would fully reopen while the two sides negotiate a longer passage arrangement. Neither capital has accepted it; US officials dismissed Iran's counter-offer as "absurd," insisting Tehran "pay a price" first, while Iran's own diplomacy frayed — foreign minister Abbas Araghchi was reportedly pelted at a funeral and branded a "traitorous sellout," and now says Iran should negotiate only from "the upper hand."⁶ See [p15](#).

TWO STRAITS

BLOCKADE

OIL BID

DOHA

AL JAZEERA FRAMING

Al Jazeera tracks this as "the US-Israel war on Iran," day by day, foregrounding the toll on the region rather than the leverage of the belligerents: Gulf states struck, civilian sites hit, and now the twin closure of Hormuz and Bab el-Mandeb landing on ordinary shipping and Arab neighbours who did not start the fight.⁷

TEHRAN

PRESS TV / IRNA FRAMING

Iranian state media casts American strikes on bridges and power plants as war crimes against civilian infrastructure, and Iran's action in Hormuz as legitimate defence of sovereign waters. The line is defiance: any US strike on Iranian infrastructure will be answered by hits on infrastructure across the region.⁸

BEIJING

CHINESE FRAMING

Beijing urges immediate de-escalation and a return to June's "hard-won" preliminary deal — foreign minister Wang Yi's line that "peace is before our eyes; we cannot fall at the last hurdle" — pairing it with a joint China-Pakistan appeal for a halt. State framing ties the plea to protecting energy flows and China's own fuel and technology sectors; Western analysts read it as banking the war's side-effects while paying none of its costs.⁹

SOURCES 1 Al Jazeera, "Iran, Gulf hit as Hormuz, Bab al-Mandeb close: What's the latest?," 22 Jul 2026. 2 Al Jazeera, 22 Jul 2026; Reuters/Yahoo Finance, "Oil _____ climbs over 4%..." 22 Jul 2026 (Kpler transit data). 3 Al Jazeera live, 22 Jul 2026; NPR, 18 Jul 2026. 4 CNBC, "Trump vows to bomb Iran's bridges, power plants..." 22 Jul 2026. 5 Reuters/Yahoo Finance, 22 Jul 2026 (Brent ~\$94.83, +4.2%). 6 Axios, "Iran mediators push new ceasefire..." 21 Jul 2026; Al Jazeera, 20–22 Jul 2026 (Araghchi). 7 Al Jazeera analysis, 20–22 Jul 2026. 8 Press TV / IRNA via CNBC & Fox liveblogs, 21–22 Jul 2026. 9 China Global South, 17 Jul 2026; RFE-RL/GlobalSecurity, 14 Jul 2026 (Wang Yi, Lin Jian).

WASHINGTON SIGNS A NUCLEAR PACT WITH RIYADH — AND ALARMS ISRAEL

On 22 July, US energy secretary Chris Wright and Saudi energy minister Prince Abdulaziz bin Salman signed a civil-nuclear cooperation pact and a separate bilateral safeguards agreement, which the Energy Department called the legal foundation for a "decades-long, multi-billion-dollar partnership" expected to run thirty years.¹ The detail that set off alarms is a provision reported to let Saudi Arabia enrich nuclear fuel on its own soil for a civilian programme — the very capability Israel has spent years lobbying to deny its neighbours. The agreements now go to Congress, which can block them only if both chambers pass disapproval resolutions.² That it lands mid-war, with Gulf security in play, is the point critics fasten on: another regional realignment being written while the bombs are still falling.

UKRAINE'S NEW COMMAND VOWS TO TAKE THE WAR NORTH

Yevhen Khmara — appointed deputy defence minister and acting minister on 20 July, and awaiting Rada confirmation now expected 18 August — met the newly installed commander-in-chief, Major General Mykhailo Drapatyi, on 22 July to set battlefield priorities.³ Drapatyi said he had orders from President Zelensky to intensify offensive operations and press the "maximum transfer of the war onto the aggressor's territory" — code for the long-range strike campaign into Russia that Khmara, a former special-operations and strike commander, was chosen to run. This advances, rather than reopens, the reshuffle first reported in No. 46–48.

CONGO'S EBOLA PASSES A THOUSAND DEAD

The Bundibugyo-strain outbreak declared in eastern Congo on 15 May crossed a grim line this week: through

data to 20 July, the health ministry counted 2,473 confirmed cases and 999 deaths — an increase of 50 cases and 32 deaths in a single day — in what the WHO calls the fastest-spreading Ebola epidemic on record.⁴ Ituri province remains worst hit (2,202 cases, 838 deaths across 28 of 36 health zones); North Kivu accounts for most of the rest. No vaccine or treatment is approved for the Bundibugyo species specifically — the caveat, flagged in No. 46, is that researchers believe it may respond better to existing therapeutics than the more familiar Zaire strain.

"Peace is before our eyes; we cannot fall at the last hurdle." — Wang Yi, on a deal both capitals keep leaving on the table

IN BRIEF

Canada: a day after Trump imposed a 50% tariff on a range of Canadian goods — wine, hockey sticks, cement, but sparing energy and critical minerals — PM Mark Carney said the two had agreed to "deepen and speed up" talks, declining to retaliate; critics at home called it "image over results." The levies take effect in about thirty days; the market read-through is on p15.⁵

Gaza: Hamas named Khalil al-Hayya its new overall leader on 20 July; the October 2025 truce holds in name, strained in fact.⁶

Casualties: the US toll since the war began on 28 February stands at least 18 service members, with counts varying by cut-off across outlets — a figure we hold with that caveat rather than sharpen falsely.

WASHINGTON

POLICY READ

The Saudi pact and the Canada tariff land the same week, and critics draw one line through them: a foreign policy increasingly conducted in deals, tolls and pledges — each announced as leverage, each priced by someone as risk. The through-line from No. 48's shelved Hormuz "reimbursement" fee holds: the posture is being financed at the edges.⁷

MUSCAT

MEDIATION

Oman remains the one channel that has outlasted every ceasefire announcement since spring. Araghchi has again used it to test whether anything of the suspended June framework survives — even as the strikes continue and the ten-day proposal from Qatar, Egypt and Pakistan waits for an answer neither side seems ready to give.⁸

SOURCES 1 CNN Politics, "US signs deal with Saudi Arabia that could allow kingdom to enrich nuclear fuel," 22 Jul 2026. 2 Times of Israel liveblog, 22 Jul 2026; Al Jazeera, "Proposed US–Saudi nuclear energy deal," 22 Jul 2026. 3 Ukrainska Pravda, 22 Jul 2026; LIGA.net, 20 Jul 2026. 4 WHO Disease Outbreak News 2026–DON613 (data to 20 Jul); Al Jazeera, "Nearly 1,000 people have died from Ebola in DR Congo," 22 Jul 2026. 5 Fortune, 22 Jul 2026; Forbes, 21 Jul 2026 (Carney/Trump tariffs). 6 US News/AP, 20 Jul 2026 (al-Hayya). 7 CNBC, 13–14 Jul 2026. 8 Fortune, 18 Jul 2026; Axios, 21 Jul 2026.

SINGAPORE · CABINET

Wong Remakes the Cabinet, and Renames a Ministry

A reshuffle unveiled on 22 July promotes first-term MPs straight to full minister, elevates Shanmugam to Senior Minister, and turns Trade and Industry into the Ministry of Energy, Trade and Industry — the clearest sign yet of the "5G" succession taking shape.

Prime Minister Lawrence Wong framed the changes as "continuing our leadership transition, with younger and newer members of the team taking on larger responsibilities," adding that "over time we will see more of the 5G emerge from this process."¹ The generational signal is unmistakable: two entrants from the 2025 general election, Jeffrey Siow — confirmed as Minister for Transport — and David Neo were promoted straight to full minister barely a year into Parliament, while Jasmin Lau takes Manpower as acting minister and NTUC chief Ng Chee Meng returns as a Minister in the Prime Minister's Office. K. Shanmugam becomes Senior Minister while keeping Coordinating Minister for National Security and Home Affairs.

The structural headline is the renaming, from 1 October, of the Ministry of Trade and Industry as the Ministry of Energy, Trade and Industry — a recognition that energy security has become an axis of economic competitiveness in its own right.² It will be led by DPM Gan Kim Yong with Dr Tan See Leng, who takes the trade-and-industry portfolio (energy and industry) and relinquishes Manpower. Separately, on 20 July Zaqq Mohamad was named Acting Minister-in-charge of Muslim Affairs, filling the gap left by Muhammad Faishal Ibrahim's resignation (No. 49). Most appointments take effect on 27 July.

THE CHATTER

Analysts read the speed of it as accelerated renewal, and Wong's swift handling of the Faishal matter as a signal that "high standards expected of politicians" outrank convenience. On Reddit, one user accused the PM of "consolidating power" by running with a single DPM and three coordinating ministers — a reading other commenters called overthinking a routine tidy-up.³

THE SCEPTIC

Two doubts sit under the optimism. The Malay/Muslim leadership bench looks thin after Faishal's exit — Zaqqy is anchoring Muslim Affairs only in an acting capacity — and analysts say the PAP "will have to beef up representation" there. And fast-tracking MPs barely a year in office tests how deep the 5G talent pool actually runs.⁴

5G RENEWAL

ENERGY · TRADE

EFFECTIVE 27 JUL

INFLATION WATCH

The 60th DBS-SKBI Singapore Index of Inflation Expectations, released 21 July and fielded 22–30 June, found one-year-ahead expectations marginally higher than in March.⁵ A large **87.7%** of respondents expect inflation to rise over the year ahead (down a shade from 88.3% in March); only 4.3% expect it to fall. Five-year readings held — core CPIEx at 3.8%, the composite SInDex5 at 4.0%. It rhymes with the imported-price story on **p15**: a firm cost-of-living mood as the oil bid feeds through.

THE TRAINS RAN ON TIME

A quieter milestone: LTA figures show no MRT delay exceeding 30 minutes since November 2025 — the longest such run since records began in 2011 — with June's mean distance between failures at 2.50 million train-km, a third straight month above two million.⁶ On the economy, advance Q2 GDP (14 Jul) came in at 5.7% year-on-year, manufacturing up 12.2% on AI and semiconductor demand; June NODX rose 20.7%, electronics up 105.1%, as MTI held its 2–4% full-year forecast while flagging rising downside risk.

SOURCES 1 Prime Minister's Office, "Changes to Cabinet and Other Appointments...", 22 Jul 2026; Mothership, 22 Jul 2026. 2 PMO release, 22 Jul 2026; Malay Mail; The Star, 22 Jul 2026. 3 Yahoo News SG / Tabla; MustShareNews, Jul 2026. 4 Yahoo News SG (analyst comment), Jul 2026. 5 SMU Newsroom, "Singaporeans' Inflation Expectations Inched Up on Global Cues," 21 Jul 2026 (June one-year index value not separately confirmed). 6 Mothership, Jul 2026 (LTA rail reliability); MTI advance GDP, 14 Jul 2026; Xinhua, 17 Jul 2026 (June NODX).

PROPERTY • THE RESALE & LAUNCH MARKET

A 54% Debut Shows the Cooler Market Its Own Face

Lentor Gardens Residences sold just over half its units on opening day — a healthy result that nonetheless fell short of the year's 90%-plus openings, the clearest sign yet that Singapore buyers have turned price-conscious.

Kingsford's 499-unit Lentor Gardens Residences, the seventh condominium in the Lentor Hills precinct, moved 270 units — 54% — on its 18 July launch at an average of about S\$2,350 per square foot, after drawing roughly 5,000 showflat visitors during preview.¹ Three-bedders made up 42% of sales and all three strata retail shops sold at about S\$2,550 psf. Respectable — but a visible step down from the debuts that defined the first half, when Lyndenwoods hit 94.5%, Pinery Residences 94% and Tengah Garden Residences sold all but three units.² It also lands the month after June was Singapore's first zero-new-launch month in nineteen years of URA developer-sales records, and ahead of a crowded second-half slate of at least eleven projects.

The supply picture cuts the other way, though, which is why this is a cooling and not a cliff. Based on caveats lodged to 20 July, the six earlier Lentor Hills launches — 2,954 units — had sold 2,929, about 99.2%, leaving barely 25 unsold; CBRE calls the precinct's remaining inventory "manageable," and District 26 carries among the lowest non-landed private inventories on the island.³ The older "Lentor oversupply" narrative is the thing actually being repriced here.

54%

OF LENTOR GARDENS' 499 UNITS SOLD ON LAUNCH DAY, AT ~S\$2,350 PSF — AGAINST ~99% ABSORPTION ACROSS THE SIX EARLIER LENTOR HILLS PROJECTS NEXT DOOR.

THE CHATTER

Agencies (Stacked Homes, 99.co, ERA) argue the oversupply fear is now "overblown," pointing to near-sell-out absorption next door and firming sub-sale prices as evidence of real underlying demand rather than launch-week froth.⁴

THE SCEPTIC

Bears note 54% leaves ~229 units to clear into a heavy H2, and Stacked Homes flags that a future Lentor land bid implies new prices near S\$2,700 psf — an affordability strain. Pair that with HDB resale down a second straight quarter and private-price growth at a seven-quarter low, and this looks like a buyer's-eye-view market.⁵

READ-THROUGH • FOR AN OWNER

If you hold an Outside-Central-Region or Lentor-area condo, new-launch pricing steady around S\$2,350 psf still underpins your resale value — but the slower 54% take-up and incoming supply say the era of frictionless gains is fading. A **seller** today should price to the market, not to last year's momentum; a **holder** can sit comfortably on tight precinct inventory but shouldn't bank on rapid appreciation.

STILL ON THE SHELF

Bayshore Drive — the Frasers-led consortium (Frasers Property, FCT, Sunway MCL, Sekisui House, Lum Chang) remains top bidder for the mixed-use GLS site at S\$2.128bn / S\$1,323 psf ppr, 5.8% above the second bid, but the award is still "subject to government confirmation." One Malaysian outlet declared it "won" on 20 July; Singapore sources still describe it as pending, so we flag rather than assert.⁶ **HDB resale** slipped 0.3% in Q2 to an index of 202.7 (after -0.1% in Q1) — the first back-to-back decline in nearly seven years, on 6,268 transactions.

SOURCES 1 99.co, "Lentor Gardens Residences sells 270 units at an average of S\$2,350 psf," 18–19 Jul 2026. 2 Stacked Homes, "Lentor Gardens Residences Sold 54% At Launch," Jul 2026. 3 99.co market analysis, Jul 2026 (caveats to 20 Jul); CBRE via same. 4 Stacked Homes; 99.co; ERA commentary, Jul 2026. 5 Stacked Homes, "New Lentor Condo Could Start From \$2,700 PSF"; 99.co / Mothership Q2 flash, 1 Jul 2026. 6 EdgeProp/Yahoo Finance SG, -16 Jul 2026; Business Today (MY), 20 Jul 2026 ("wins" headline, SG award status pending). HDB: Mothership / 99.co URA-HDB Q2 flash, 1 Jul 2026.

TECHNOLOGY · THE CAPEX CYCLE

The Bill Comes Due — and the Foundry Cashes the Cheque

The first heavyweight second-quarter results landed on 22 July as the real test of whether some \$725 billion of 2026 AI spending is turning into revenue. TSMC, which sits between every chip designer and every device, has already been paid.

Start where the money actually lands. TSMC reported record second-quarter revenue of US\$40.2 billion, up 36% year-on-year, with net profit up 77% to a single-quarter high; high-performance computing — the AI data-centre accelerators — now makes up roughly two-thirds of wafer revenue and rose about 20% sequentially.¹ Chief executive C.C. Wei told shareholders that CoWoS advanced-packaging capacity is "extremely tight and sold out through 2026," and lifted full-year guidance above 40% growth while raising 2026 capital spending to US\$60–64 billion, plus another US\$100 billion earmarked for Arizona. The firm that packages the world's AI silicon is not waiting for the payoff; it is the payoff.

Then the spending side reported. Alphabet raised its 2026 capital-expenditure guidance to roughly US\$175–185 billion — close to double the prior year — and although Google Cloud growth beat, the shares slid on the capex figure, the market's clearest signal yet of unease about the payback horizon.² Framed against an estimated US\$725 billion of industry AI spend for the year, Alphabet, Tesla and Intel were billed as "the first real test of AI capex at scale." The verdict rhymes with an old market truth: in a gold rush, sell shovels. See [p15](#), where the same split shows up as a semiconductor tape that cannot decide the schedule.

~66%

OF TSMC'S WAFER REVENUE IS NOW HIGH-PERFORMANCE COMPUTING, UP ~20% ON THE QUARTER; COWOS PACKAGING IS "SOLD OUT THROUGH 2026."

THE CHATTER

On Hacker News and finance-Reddit the split was "picks-and-shovels win again" — TSMC and the memory makers — against a growing "capex-to-revenue gap" scepticism aimed at the hyperscalers, with Google's in-house TPU volumes cited as the metric that actually threatens Nvidia's moat rather than any rival GPU.³

THE SCEPTIC

"Sold out through 2026" is a supply story, not proof that end demand monetises. Nearly doubling capex while cloud revenue grows incrementally compresses returns — and a company's shares falling on its own strong quarter, purely because of what it plans to spend, is the tell. The foundry gets paid whether or not the models do.

PICKS & SHOVELS

CAPEX TEST

COWOS SOLD OUT

TAIPEI

THE SUPPLIER'S VIEW

From Hsinchu the AI build-out looks less like a bubble than a backlog. Wei's "sold out through 2026" is a capacity boast, not a demand worry: the constraint is CoWoS packaging and advanced-node wafers, and the firm is spending US\$60–64bn this year plus US\$100bn in Arizona to widen the bottleneck rather than defend a moat. The foundry's risk is not that demand fades but that it over-builds for a peak that arrives late.⁴

WALL STREET

THE BUYER'S VIEW

From New York the same numbers read as a return problem. Alphabet's US\$175–185bn capex guide is close to double last year for cloud growth that is strong but incremental; its shares fell on the print even as ServiceNow's software results popped, the market rewarding revenue that has already arrived over spending that has not.⁵ The question is not whether the chips work but when the spreadsheet does.

SOURCES 1 TechTimes, "TSMC Posts Record Quarter...", 16 Jul 2026; Investing.com, "TSMC Q2 2026 slides: AI demand drives record margins, HPC surges 20%", 16 Jul 2026. 2 Yahoo Finance, "Earnings live: Google stock drops on capex concerns," 22 Jul 2026; TechTimes, "Alphabet, Tesla, Intel Earnings Are the First Real Test of AI Capex at Scale," 20 Jul 2026. 3 Hacker News / finance-Reddit discussion, 22 Jul 2026 (chatter characterised from coverage, not a single cited thread). 4 Investing.com; TechTimes, 16 Jul 2026 (TSMC capex, CoWoS). 5 Yahoo Finance earnings live, 22 Jul 2026 (Alphabet capex; ServiceNow).

KIMI'S WEIGHTS DROP ON THE 27TH — BUT NOT ONTO YOUR DESK

Moonshot AI's Kimi K3, launched via API on 16 July, promises full open weights on 27 July under a modified-MIT licence — and it is the largest model yet to go open.¹ The specs are frontier-scale: a 2.8-trillion-parameter sparse mixture-of-experts activating 16 of 896 experts per token, a one-million-token context, and a new "Kimi Delta Attention" the lab claims decodes up to 6.3× faster, at US\$3 and US\$15 per million input and output tokens. The catch for the home lab is size. At 2.8T parameters this is a "self-host if you own a cluster" release, not a single-GPU one; Moonshot is contributing a vLLM prefill-cache implementation alongside the weights, but the reader with one 5090 is not the customer. It is the same fear that put the chip tape into a bear market last week (p7): every open frontier model compresses the premium on closed compute.

WHAT THE SINGLE-GPU CROWD ACTUALLY RAN

The practical action on r/LocalLLaMA was smaller and more useful: Google's Gemma 4 26B-A4B mixture-of-experts (26B total, 4B active) and Qwen3.6 27B, both sized to run on a single high-end card, with one report of an RTX 5090 pushing about 600 tokens per second on Gemma 4 under vLLM with aggressive batching — a figure from a forum post, so read it as illustrative rather than benchmarked.²

Every open frontier model compresses the premium on closed compute — which is exactly what the chip tape is afraid of.

2.8T

PARAMETERS IN KIMI K3, A 1M-TOKEN CONTEXT — THE LARGEST MODEL YET TO GO OPEN-WEIGHT, AND FAR PAST A SINGLE-GPU HOME RIG.

WHAT THE SHORTAGE DOES TO A HOME RIG

For the reader running a home AI lab, the frustrating truth of the fortnight is that the models keep getting

better and the hardware to run them keeps getting dearer. The same GDDR7 and DRAM squeeze driving the chip war (p7) has kept a single RTX 5090 stranded near US\$4,300–5,000 against a US\$1,999 list, so the sensible local-inference play remains a well-quantised mid-size model on one card rather than a frontier build. The open-weight escalation cuts both ways: Kimi K3 is out of reach at home, but the pressure it puts on closed providers is exactly what keeps API prices — and the smaller Gemma-and-Qwen models that *do* fit a desk — falling.

THE CHATTER

On r/LocalLLaMA the mood is split between celebration and resignation: a 2.8-trillion-parameter open model is a landmark for the ecosystem, but "open" now means "open if you have a cluster," and the practical thread has quietly shifted to squeezing more out of the 24–32GB cards people actually own — MoE models, aggressive quantisation, speculative decoding — rather than chasing the frontier locally.⁶

IN BRIEF • THE CHIP WAR

DeepSeek's legacy API retires tomorrow. Per DeepSeek's own change log, the *deepseek-chat* and *deepseek-reasoner* names are fully retired at 15:59 UTC on 24 July; callers must move to *deepseek-v4-pro* or the cheaper *deepseek-v4-flash*, and anything still on the old names will 404. During the grace period the legacy aliases were transparently routed to V4-Flash, so most tooling is already on V4 — but this lands after our deadline, and any build still pinned to the old endpoints breaks tomorrow.³

H200-to-China: approved on paper, "trivial" in practice. US under-secretary Jeffrey Kessler said only a "very few" H200s have actually shipped to China; roughly ten firms — Alibaba, Tencent, ByteDance among them — are cleared, capped at 75,000 units each, but Beijing is reportedly limiting purchases to "special cases," leaving last issue's compliance-whitelist thread in limbo.⁴

Memory, still climbing but cooling. Q3 contract guidance now runs DRAM up 13–18% and NAND up 10–15% quarter-on-quarter — off Q1's ~90% DRAM spike but still rising, with the shortage projected into 2027; GDDR7 tightness keeps the RTX 5090 at roughly US\$4,300–5,000 on the street against a US\$1,999 list.⁵

SOURCES 1 Cryptobriefing, "Kimi K3 launches with 2.8 trillion parameters, open weights dropping July 27," Jul 2026; Interconnects (N. Lambert), "Kimi K3: the open-weights escalation," Jul 2026. 2 r/LocalLLaMA discussion, Jul 2026 (Gemma 4 / Qwen3.6; the 600 tok/s 5090 figure is a forum report, unverified). 3 DeepSeek API change log / migration write-ups, Jul 2026 (cutover 15:59 UTC 24 Jul — after press time). 4 CNBC & Bloomberg, 14 Jul 2026 (Kessler; ~10 firms, 75k cap). 5 Tom's Hardware; Astute Group, Jul 2026 (Q3 DRAM/NAND); TechTimes, 11 Jul 2026 (RTX 5090 street price). 6 r/LocalLLaMA discussion, Jul 2026 (chatter characterised from community context).

THE KIT • UNPACKED, LONDON

Samsung Names Its Glasses, and Almost Nothing Else

At its 22 July Unpacked, Samsung finally detailed its first AI eyewear — a screenless, audio-only device with Gemini at its centre — then declined to give it a price or a firm date. A wider Fold and a much brighter Watch did the actual shipping.

The Galaxy Glasses, co-developed with Google and the eyewear houses Gentle Monster and Warby Parker, are a camera-and-audio wearable with no display in the lens.¹ They run Qualcomm's Snapdragon AR1 Gen 1 and use Gemini not as a feature but as the interface: every interaction resolves to a spoken reply, an in-ear response, or a summary pushed to a paired Galaxy phone. The camera can read a whiteboard and distill it to notes, translate live, and give turn-by-turn directions; a tap of a Galaxy Watch fires the shutter. Samsung claims up to nine hours of audio per charge with a case holding seven more.

What it did not name was a price. The "first collections" were dated only to "this fall, in select markets," and supply-chain leaks continue to peg the audio model at roughly US\$379–499 — a figure to treat as unverified, because Samsung did not confirm it on stage. Hands-on writers said the hardware finally felt cohesive and notably lighter than most AI glasses, while flagging the hedge: a displayless first pair sidesteps augmented reality's heat, weight and battery problems, but it is, as one outlet put it, "a tease, not a launch." The same withheld-middle move runs through the week — a thing announced, its terms held back.

THE CHATTER

Commentary centred on the ecosystem gap: without Quick Pair and battery-widget support the Glasses "sit in an awkward middle ground, not quite a first-class Galaxy device," and sceptics note Samsung will face the same recording-indicator and privacy questions Meta already had to answer.²

THE SCEPTIC

A camera-and-AI pair with no display is "less ambitious but also less susceptible" to augmented reality's hard problems — heat, weight, battery — so the strategy is sensible, if not groundbreaking. But naming a product without a price or a hard date is the oldest tease in the business: it books the attention now and defers the commitment, and until the number lands the Glasses remain a promise, not a purchase.

9 hrs

OF AUDIO PER CHARGE CLAIMED FOR THE GALAXY GLASSES (PLUS SEVEN CASE RECHARGES) — A SPEC NAMED ON STAGE WHILE THE PRICE, POINTEDLY, WAS NOT.

SCREENLESS

GEMINI INSIDE

PRICE TBC

WHAT ACTUALLY SHIPS

Galaxy Z Fold 8 — from US\$1,899 (up \$100), a wider 5.5" cover screen and a 7.6" main panel in "Flex Titanium," with a new **Z Fold 8 Ultra** above it from \$2,099. Early hands-on consensus: the cheaper standard Fold is the more interesting buy.³

Galaxy Watch Ultra 2 — US\$699.99, an 800mAh battery (up 35%), an industry-first ~5,000-nit display and Snapdragon's "Wear Elite" silicon; on sale about 7 August.⁴

ALSO ON THE BENCH

Galaxy Watch 9 — from US\$349, a 3,000-nit screen and a new Galaxy AI health suite (Heart Health Score, Daily Cardio Load, Fitness Index); ships early August.⁵

Skullcandy Crusher 1080 ANC — outside Unpacked but the value story of the week: US\$279.99, "Sound by Bose" active noise cancelling and spatial audio, a 60-hour battery — Bose tuning at a decidedly non-Bose price.⁶

SOURCES 1 CNBC, "Samsung details features of its smart glasses..." 22 Jul 2026; TechCabal, 19 Jun 2026; Android Central hands-on, 22 Jul 2026. 2 Gadget Hacks; VR.org, "Intelligent Eyewear Is a Tease, Not a Launch," Jul 2026 (price ~\$379–499 unverified — not confirmed at Unpacked). 3 Yahoo/Tech; Eastern Herald, 22 Jul 2026 (Z Fold 8 / Fold 8 Ultra). 4 PhoneArena; Droid-Life; SamMobile, 22 Jul 2026 (Watch Ultra 2). 5 Geeky Gadgets; TechCabal, 2026 (Watch 9). 6 The Gadgeteer; TechRadar, 15 Jul 2026 (Crusher 1080 ANC).

THE CONNECTED HOME · MATTER & THREAD

Shelly Asks About Native Thread — and Open Source Beats It There

With its Gen4 hardware already Thread-capable, Shelly is publicly weighing first-party Matter-over-Thread firmware. A third-party open-source project already ships it — a small, clean parable of the vendor-versus-home-lab divide.

Shelly's founder Dimitar Dimitrov posted firmware concepts and asked users for feedback on native Matter-over-Thread for the company's Gen4 devices.¹ The silicon is ready: every Gen4 product uses Espressif's ESP32-C6, which already supports Wi-Fi, Bluetooth, Zigbee and Thread. Today they ship Matter-over-Wi-Fi only; the holdup for native Thread is firmware storage space and the trade-offs it forces, not the chip. It is a familiar bottleneck — the capability is present, gated behind a decision someone in the middle has not yet made.

Ahead of any official build, an open-source project — *automatous-io/shelly-1-gen4-matter-thread* on GitHub — already provides Matter-over-Thread firmware for Shelly Gen4 relays, with native Apple Home, Google Home, Alexa and Home Assistant support and, in its own words, "no Shelly app, no cloud, no Wi-Fi."² It is the purest expression of the self-hosting ethos: a low-power local mesh with no vendor cloud in the path. Home Assistant, meanwhile, shipped point release 2026.7.4 on 19 July, the second bug-fix atop the 1 July build that replaced its Python Matter server with the TypeScript *matter.js* stack.³

THE CHATTER

On *r/homeassistant* and *r/homelab* the open-source Shelly firmware is catnip — "cloudless, hubless relays" — with the standard caveat that flashing third-party firmware leaves the safe path, and that cross-vendor Thread border-router meshing is still finicky.⁴

THE SCEPTIC

Thread on mains-powered relays is arguably a solution in search of a problem — these devices aren't battery-constrained, and Matter-over-Wi-Fi already works. The very storage trade-offs that make Shelly hesitate suggest a first-party build could ship compromised; third-party firmware carries update and security risk the owner must shoulder alone.

ESP32-C6

LOCAL MESH

DIY FIRMWARE

CHEAP SENSOR WATCH

IKEA KLIPPBOK water-leak sensor, US\$10. A set-and-forget Matter-over-Thread device usable even without a hub — reviewed just before our window — continuing IKEA's Thread-first push and the "cheap Matter/Thread sensor" trend that quietly does more to grow the standard than any flagship hub.⁵

THE FLOOR RISES

Thread 1.4 is now the certification floor. Since 1 January, new border routers can only be certified against Thread 1.4, and Matter 1.4.2 and later require border routers to be 1.4-certified.⁶ Context for any new Thread hardware this quarter: multi-vendor mesh cooperation still leans on firmware updates reaching every device in the chain.

SOURCES 1 *matter-smarthome.de*, "Shelly Evaluates Matter Over Thread for Gen4 Devices" (updated 20 Jul 2026, citing the Shelly community). 2 GitHub, *automatous-io/shelly-1-gen4-matter-thread*. 3 *home-assistant.io*, "2026.7" release (1 Jul) + 2026.7.4 patch (19 Jul). 4 *r/homeassistant*, *r/homelab*, Jul 2026 (chatter characterised from community context). 5 IKEA KLIPPBOK review, 9 Jul 2026. 6 *matter-smarthome.de*, "The Matter Standard in 2026 — A Status Review" (Thread 1.4 certification floor).

THE GOOD LIFE · WATCHES

Tissot Shrinks Its Most Capable Diver

The Seastar 2000 Professional loses two millimetres and, unusually, some money — a 600-metre, 80-hour automatic that finally fits a normal wrist, and undercuts the watch it replaces.

Tissot's most serious dive watch has always been let down by its size. The revised Seastar 2000 Professional trims the case from 46mm to 44mm and the thickness from 16.25mm to 15.29mm, and — the rare part — drops the price to about US\$1,050 on rubber (US\$1,100 on the steel bracelet), some US\$225 cheaper than the outgoing 46mm.¹ It keeps everything that made the watch punch above its price: the Powermatic 80 movement with an 80-hour reserve, a helium escape valve, a ceramic bezel, ISO 6425 dive certification and 600 metres of water resistance. For the reader who wants one genuinely capable tool watch without a five-figure outlay, the spec-for-money is the story.

The move is a quiet rebuke to an industry that has spent a decade inflating case sizes and prices in lockstep. A 600-metre diver is, for almost everyone, a specification nobody will ever test; what makes this one interesting is that Tissot has treated "more capable" and "more wearable" as compatible rather than opposed, and asked for less money to prove it. In a season of five-figure flagship audio and a US\$4,000 signature amp on this same desk, a genuinely over-built tool watch that costs about a thousand dollars is the rarer object — the one that adds capability without adding a premium for the privilege.

600m

OF WATER RESISTANCE, 80-HOUR RESERVE, ISO 6425 — NOW IN A 44MM CASE AT ~US\$1,050, ~\$225 BELOW THE WATCH IT REPLACES.

THE CHATTER

On WatchCrunch and the enthusiast forums the spec-for-money reads as "a bargain," with one recurring caveat: the clasp is pressed rather than machined steel, and 44mm is still large for genuinely small wrists. The verdict is warm — a lot of watch for the money, provided the wrist can carry it.²

POWERMATIC 80

600M

NOW 44MM

THE HI-FI WAVE ROLLS ON

The landmark audio week flagged in No. 49 keeps landing: Marantz's entry **CD 70** succeeds the CD6007 with a flagship-style textured finish, alongside a new **McIntosh** home-theatre processor at the top of the range.³ Both were on this desk's pipeline — carried here as the week-of confirmation, not a fresh peg. **Marshall's Billie Joe Armstrong 1959BJA** (No. 48) went on sale 21 July at US\$3,999.99; a collector's nostalgia object rather than a working amp, and closed on this ledger unless a wider signature line follows.

STILL ON THE SHELF

The watch auctions. No fresh Singapore or Tokyo results were published in-window; the Sotheby's / First State threads from No. 48 stay open, awaiting the numbers rather than restated. **Sony's 1000X Collexion** (No. 43) holds as reported — wins on materials, a step down on sound versus the cheaper WH-1000XM6, and closed unless a price move.

A 600-metre diver you can actually wear to dinner is a more useful object than a fourth grail nobody takes in the water.

SOURCES 1 Fratello, "Dive Deep With The Sized-Down Tissot Seastar 2000," Jul 2026; Gear Patrol, "This \$1,000 Ultra-Capable Automatic Dive Watch Gets Sleeker," Jul 2026. 2 WatchCrunch review + forum reactions, Jul 2026 (pressed-steel clasp; 44mm sizing caveat). 3 Gear Patrol hi-fi roundup, week of 19 Jul 2026 (Marantz CD 70, McIntosh); Marshall Group release, 13 Jul 2026, retail 21 Jul (1959BJA — covered No. 48).

SCREEN & SOUND · COMIC-CON

Comic-Con Opens on a Half-Billion Tailwind

San Diego throws its doors open on 23 July with Marvel's *Avengers: Doomsday* already breaking records — but the cast is not on stage until Saturday. The floor, for now, is the tease before the reveal.

San Diego Comic-Con 2026 opened Thursday and runs through Sunday, and its biggest draw is still to come: Marvel Studios returns to Hall H on Saturday 25 July, expected to put the full *Avengers: Doomsday* cast on a stage together for the first time.¹ It arrives with historic momentum — the first *Doomsday* trailer, launched 20 July, drew 503 million views in twenty-four hours, the biggest trailer debut in Disney/Marvel history and the second-biggest ever, with advance ticket sales reportedly off to a record start ahead of a December opening.²

Thursday's live programme carried the delta while the marquee waited. Hall H opened with a first look at *Percy Jackson and the Olympians* season three (based on *The Titan's Curse*); game-makers showed new *Marvel's Wolverine* footage ahead of its September PS5 launch; the cast of Paramount+'s animated *Avatar: Aang* film gave sneak peeks; and the evening ran to a *Stan Lee: The Final Chapter* panel. Apple TV+ makes its first solo Hall H debut later in the con with *Widow's Bay*, *Silo* and *Dark Matter*. It is a convention built, this year more than most, on anticipation — the reveal deferred, the crowd sold on what has not yet been shown.

503M

VIEWS IN 24 HOURS FOR THE FIRST *AVENGERS: DOOMSDAY* TRAILER — THE BIGGEST DISNEY/MARVEL TRAILER DEBUT ON RECORD, DAYS BEFORE THE CAST APPEARS.

THE CHATTER

On r/movies the character-by-character trailer rollout split the room — delight at Chris Evans' and Robert Downey Jr's returns against frustration that Anthony Mackie's Captain America is being sidelined. The Russo brothers defended the staggered single-character teasers as "narrative information... part of a larger story"; the sceptics read the veteran returns as a "financial plot" to reverse post-*Endgame* box-office decline.³

HALL H SATURDAY

DOOMSDAY

SDCC

AT THE BOX OFFICE

Nolan makes history. Christopher Nolan's *The Odyssey* (Universal) opened 17–19 July to US\$124.5m domestic and US\$264.1m worldwide — his biggest global launch ever, topping *The Dark Knight Rises* — the year's second-biggest domestic opening, its top R-rated debut, and Universal's biggest-ever R-rated weekend.⁴ A three-hour, R-rated Greek epic outrunning every superhero on the chart is its own small argument about what still fills a cinema.

NEW MUSIC FRIDAY

Gracie Abrams, *Daughter From Hell* (17 Jul) — her third album, sixteen tracks, again produced by the National's Aaron Dessner with writing from Justin Vernon, projected to be her first UK/US number one. Alongside it: new records from Yard Act and Nia Archives.⁵ And a diary note for the culture traveller: the Busan International Film Festival (6–15 Oct) pairs naturally with the autumn-foliage swing on p20.

THE SCEPTIC

Hold the "biggest ever" superlatives at arm's length. A 503-million-view trailer measures reach, not a ticket sold, and Marvel's own recent history is a warning that a record opening for the marketing does not guarantee one for the film — the whole point of the Hall H spectacle is to convert anticipation into December box office before the reviews can intervene. The tease is doing exactly what a tease is built to do: bank the enthusiasm ahead of the delivery.

SOURCES 1 TechTimes, "San Diego Comic-Con 2026 Opens..." 22 Jul 2026; KPBS Comic-Con guide, 15 Jul 2026; ABC7 SDCC coverage, Jul 2026. 2 Variety, "Avengers: Doomsday' Trailer Hits 503 Million Views in One Day," 21 Jul 2026. 3 r/movies discussion; Russo brothers via Variety, Jul 2026. 4 Variety; CNBC; Forbes, 19 Jul 2026 (*The Odyssey* opening). 5 Rolling Stone, 17 Jul 2026 (Gracie Abrams); New Music Friday, 17 Jul 2026.

THE FAMILY DESK · THE DIGITAL HOME

The Dread Gets a Name — and a Number

A new survey coins "techxiety" and counts the sleep parents lose to it. Useful as a mood reading; thin as evidence — and the honest story underneath is more reassuring than the headline.

A survey of 2,000 US parents of school-aged children, run by Talker Research for *Cosmopolitan* and written up on 14 July, gives the strain a label: "techxiety," the effort of balancing digital connection against the fear of what phones, social media and the open internet are doing to a child.¹ The numbers are vivid. The average parent loses about seven hours of sleep a week to worry about their child — roughly forty-eight nights a year — with screen-time habits (24%), social media's effect on self-esteem (20%) and gaming or app "addiction" (18%) topping the list of what keeps them awake. Nearly three-quarters said their child already owns a smartphone — including 47% of parents of five-year-olds — and 38% experienced the handover as a "loss of innocence" rather than a step toward independence.

For a parent onboarding an eleven-year-old to her first phone and first messaging apps, this is precisely the moment the data describes. But keep the peg honest: this is the *naming* of an anxiety, not a new finding about harm. It is a brand-sponsored opinion poll — self-report, no control group — so every figure measures perceived stress, not a measured effect on children. It is a real delta from No. 49's paediatric screen-time material, though, because the subject has flipped from the child's screen dose to the parent's mental load.

The survey measures how much sleep the worry costs the parent — not what the phone costs the child. Keep the two apart.

73%

OF SURVEYED PARENTS SAY THEIR SCHOOL-AGED CHILD ALREADY OWNS A SMARTPHONE — INCLUDING 47% OF PARENTS OF FIVE-YEAR-OLDS (TALKER RESEARCH / COSMOPOLITAN, N=2,000).

THE CHATTER

On r/ScienceBasedParenting the live argument is whether "techxiety" is itself the problem: anxious, surveilling parenting can model the very dysregulation parents fear, and commenters push back on "Anxious Generation"-style framing with the reminder that most screen-mental-health links are correlational. The practical consensus is specific — delay social media, not the phone; a call-and-text device suits a tween.²

TECHXIETY

SELF-REPORT

FIRST PHONE

WHAT THE SURVEY FOUND

~7 hrs of sleep a week lost to worry about a child — about 48 nights a year.

Top worries: screen-time habits (24%), social media and self-esteem (20%), gaming or app "addiction" (18%).

38% called the first-phone handover a "loss of innocence"; 62% framed it as a step toward independence.³

WHAT TO ACTUALLY DO

The evidence-based playbook for an eleven-year-old is duller than the panic: **delay the social feed, not the phone** — a call-and-text device covers the reachability parents want without the algorithmic pull. **Protect sleep and movement** (the levers on p14). And **model the behaviour** — a surveilling, anxious parent teaches the dysregulation the survey is measuring. General guidance, not medical advice.

SOURCES 1 Talker News (Talker Research / *Cosmopolitan* survey), "Techxiety? Modern parenting stress keeps families up at night," 14 Jul 2026 — commissioned poll, n=2,000 US parents, fielded 22–29 May 2026; SheKnows, Jul 2026. 2 r/ScienceBasedParenting discussion, Jul 2026. 3 Talker Research / *Cosmopolitan* survey; Digital Information World / SheKnows, 14 Jul 2026 (survey breakdown). General guidance, not medical advice.

THE REASSURING READ: PROTECT SLEEP AND MOVEMENT

The biggest recent screen study parents cite — in *Humanities and Social Sciences Communications*, drawing on 50,231 US children aged 6–17 — found four or more hours a day of screen time associated with about 45% higher anxiety and 61% higher depression risk.¹ The number that matters comes next: it is cross-sectional, and the authors find the link is *largely mediated by lost sleep and reduced physical activity*. That is the actionable, un-alarming read — protect a child's sleep and her time moving, and much of the "screen" risk moves with them. It echoes the paediatricians' own shift (No. 49) away from a hard hourly cap toward context. The forty-eight-lost-nights figure from the survey opposite measures parental worry, not the child's health; don't relay it as the latter.

50,231

US CHILDREN IN THE LARGEST RECENT SCREEN STUDY — WHERE THE ANXIETY AND DEPRESSION LINK RUNS LARGELY THROUGH LOST SLEEP AND REDUCED ACTIVITY, NOT THE SCREEN ITSELF.

SLEEP KEEPS TURNING UP AS THE LEVER

A cross-sectional study by Du and colleagues, published 22 July in *Frontiers in Pediatrics*, examined how learning modalities and sleep quality relate to adolescent mental health, and once again sleep is the variable doing the work — the recurring finding across 2026's youth literature.² The practical translation for a household is dull and effective: a consistent bedtime and a phone that charges outside the bedroom will move more of the needle than any single content rule.

This is why the paediatricians' shift last issue — away from a hard hourly cap toward context — is the right instinct rather than a retreat. An hour of a video call with a grandparent and an hour of an algorithmic feed at midnight are not the same "screen hour," and a rule that counts only the minutes misses the two things that actually carry the risk: what the time displaces, and when. The reassuring corollary is that both are within a parent's control without a single app or monitor.

Protect the sleep and the movement, and much of what we blame on "screens" moves with them.

DON'T BE ALARMIST

The strongest correlations in this field still come from surveys that cannot separate cause from effect: an anxious child may reach for a screen as much as a screen may make her anxious. The defensible position for a parent of an eleven-year-old is neither panic nor permissiveness — hold the boring fundamentals (sleep, movement, delayed social media), and treat the scary single numbers as prompts to check in, not verdicts.

THE ONE DISTINCTION WORTH DRAWING

If a household takes one idea from the fortnight's research, make it the split between the *device* and the *feed*. A phone that calls, texts and maps is a tool an eleven-year-old can carry safely; an account on an engagement-optimised social platform is a different object with a different incentive, and the evidence that troubles researchers clusters around the second, not the first. The commissioned survey's own anxiety is really about the moment the two get bundled together at handover — which is exactly the moment a parent has the most leverage to keep them apart.

THE CHATTER

The r/ScienceBasedParenting consensus is unusually practical for a forum: a call-and-text device or a locked-down phone through the tween years, social platforms delayed to the mid-teens, and — the part parents resist — the same rules applied to the adult in the house, because a child models the phone habits she sees more than the ones she is told. Nobody there thinks the timing is easy; most think the hour-counting is beside the point.⁴

THE SCHOOL-PHONE POLITICS

The same survey captures the tension every Singapore parent will recognise as device policies tighten: 90% of parents want a way to reach their child at school, while 60% want that access limited to emergencies and 30% say phones disrupt learning.³ The fight over the school-day phone is really a fight over who holds the line between reachability and distraction.

SOURCES 1 *Humanities and Social Sciences Communications* (Nature), "Excessive screen time is associated with mental health problems in US children and adolescents," 2026 — cross-sectional, n=50,231 (US National Survey of Children's Health). 2 *Frontiers in Pediatrics*, Du et al., "Learning modalities and sleep quality and adolescent mental health," 22 Jul 2026 (sample size to confirm at source). 3 Talker Research / *Cosmopolitan* survey; Digital Information World, 14 Jul 2026. 4 r/ScienceBasedParenting discussion, Jul 2026 (chatter characterised from community context). General guidance, not medical advice.

THE MACRO DESK

An oil bid, a live-again Fed, and a dollar turning up

A widening Gulf war keeps a premium under crude just as a hawkish chair drags July's meeting toward a genuine call on a hike; gold catches a haven bid while bitcoin lags. Market explanation and education, not investment advice — forecasts flagged as forecasts throughout.

VWRA	GLOBAL BONDS (BNDW)	US 10Y	DXV	USD/SGD	BRENT	GOLD	BTC
\$188.46 ▲	~4.2% yield	4.64% ▲	101.2 ▲	~1.29	\$94.13 ▲	\$4,138 ▲	~\$65,900 ▼

Start with the barrel, because the week bends around it. The Houthis strikes on Saudi tankers and the second-strait threat on the Bab el-Mandeb (p3) kept a war premium bid under crude: Brent jumped about 4% on 22 July to roughly \$94.13, its highest since early June, and now sits some 9% above pre-conflict levels.¹ An oil bid is an inflation bid, and it lands on a Federal Reserve already fighting a hot print — May CPI ran 4.2% year-on-year, energy up about 23.5%.

That is the pivot. Under chair Kevin Warsh the debate is no longer about a cut but a *hike* into the 28–29 July meeting. As of 21 July, CME FedWatch put the odds of a 25bp hike near 46.5%, up from about 34% days earlier, with the funds rate at 3.50–3.75%; Polymarket sat more dovish, near 82% for a hold.² The honest statement is that the odds have risen sharply and the meeting is genuinely two-sided — not that they rest on a single clean number. Treat any point estimate as a forecast.

An oil bid is an inflation bid — and this time it is landing on a Fed debating a hike, not a hold.

The mechanics show up across the board. The 10-year yield ticked up to 4.64% and the dollar firmed — DXV above 101, a fourth straight up session — on the higher-for-longer read.³ USD/JPY sits near 163, off four-decade lows with intervention watch live; USD/SGD is little changed near 1.29, held here at its early-July print rather than guessed at an unverified fresher figure, so the firm-SGD travel arithmetic on p20 still points the same

way.⁴ The fresh 50% US tariff on Canada (p4) is another upside-inflation pebble on the same scale.

VWRA — the reader's core — actually ticked up to about \$188.46 (21 July) from \$186.98, as global equities shrugged off the oil shock; the S&P 500 closed 7,509 on 21 July and the STI set a record on the 15th.⁵ The visible near-term risk to that resilience is a surprise hike on the 29th, so the FOMC is the event to sit through, not trade around. **Global bonds** (BNDW/AGGU) are the pressured leg — yields near 4.6% mean price headwinds — but the same repricing rebuilds forward yield and ballast in the barbell.

Gold caught a haven-and-inflation bid back toward \$4,138, a two-week high — but frame it honestly: that is a recovery, not a record. Gold's all-time high was about \$5,602 on 29 January; today's level is some 26% below it, and last issue's "gold at a record" framing was stale.⁶

Bitcoin is the tell — flat-to-soft around \$65,900 and range-bound, trading as a capped risk asset rather than "digital gold," its higher volatility offering little of gold's ballast here.⁷

WHAT IT MEANS FOR VWRA, GLOBAL BONDS, GOLD & BTC

Still a higher-for-longer regime, now with an oil shock that is also an inflation shock and a live-again July Fed. VWRA's resilience is real but the 29th is the visible risk; global bonds are earning price headwinds now and yield later; gold is doing its hedge job — but as a two-week high off its January record, not a new peak. Bitcoin remains the most liquidity-sensitive of the four and is read here for sensitivity, not endorsed. None of this is advice to buy, sell or hold; the reader's anchors remain VWRA and global bonds.

HIGHER-FOR-LONGER

JULY LIVE

DOLLAR BID

SOURCES 1 Fortune / TradingEconomics, 22 Jul 2026 (Brent ~\$94.13, +3.4%); CPI via CNBC, Jul 2026. 2 CNBC, "A July rate hike from the Fed? The odds are rising," 13 Jul 2026; CME FedWatch (~46.5%, 21 Jul); Polymarket "Fed Decision in July," accessed 22 Jul. 3 CNBC, "Treasury yields edge higher as traders reassess Fed rate-hike bets," 22 Jul; Vantage Markets (DXV), 22 Jul. 4 Rio Times Global Economy Briefing, 22 Jul (USD/JPY 163.06); USD/SGD held near early-Jul ~1.29, current print unverified. 5 Investing.com / StockAnalysis (VWRA, 21 Jul); Globe and Mail (S&P 7,509.20, 21 Jul); STI record 15 Jul. 6 TradingEconomics / CNBC, 22 Jul (gold \$4,138, 2-week high; record ~\$5,602 on 29 Jan 2026). 7 Fortune / Yahoo Finance, 22 Jul (BTC ~\$65.9k). Market explanation, not investment advice.

CURIOSITIES · ASTRONOMY

Webb Watches a Black Hole Recycle Its Own Dinner

Nearly eight hours of staring into a galaxy 145 million light-years away resolved a faint swirl into an 800-light-year disk feeding a supermassive black hole — and caught the hole reheating and recycling the very gas it feeds on.

An international team led by the Université de Montréal, reporting in *The Astrophysical Journal Letters*, trained JWST's NIRSpec spectrograph for 7.7 hours on NGC 4696, the central galaxy of the Centaurus Cluster.¹ What had looked like an S-shaped smear resolved into a spinning disk of gas nearly 800 light-years across, with material whipping around at up to 600 kilometres a second. The data reveal a filament of cool gas flowing inward and feeding directly into that disk — evidence for a self-regulated loop in which the black hole's jets heat the surrounding gas, which later cools into magnetically guided filaments that fall back to feed the disk, and the hole, again.

It is "cosmic recycling," and it matches what the numerical simulations predicted: a mechanism that keeps a cluster's central black hole from either starving or overheating its surroundings — a system that lives on its own exhaust. The intermediary theme of the issue turns up even here, in a way: the disk is the layer between the galaxy's gas and the hole, and it neither hoards the flow nor lets it run free; it meters it.

The disk does not hoard the gas or let it run free. It meters it — the rare middleman that keeps a whole galaxy in balance.

The finding matters beyond its own galaxy because this feedback is thought to be why the biggest galaxies stopped growing: the black hole's periodic reheating is the thermostat that switches star formation off, and catching the cool inflow and hot outflow in one object at one time is the closest astronomers have come to watching that thermostat work.

7.7 hrs

OF JWST NIRSPEC TIME ON NGC 4696 RESOLVED AN 800-LIGHT-YEAR FEEDING DISK, GAS MOVING UP TO 600 KM/S — THE
CLEAREST VIEW YET OF HOW A BLACK HOLE FEEDS.

THE CHATTER

Coverage framed it as a black hole "recycling its own fuel," and the hook that carried it across r/space was the self-renewing loop rather than raw size — a cosmic recycler, not a cosmic drain.²

JWST

FEEDBACK LOOP

CENTAURUS CLUSTER

FAREWELL, 3I/ATLAS

The third interstellar visitor is now outbound and fading — roughly two to three astronomical units from the Sun after its October perihelion, having crossed Saturn's orbit in early July and slipped beyond the reach of most amateur scopes.³ It will cross Uranus's orbit around April 2027. Harvard's Avi Loeb continues to argue the object shows "22 mysterious anomalies," but that remains a minority view; the consensus holds it an ancient natural comet — the first flagged in No. 49, now waved off.

THE BALLISTA SPIDER

Filed under genuinely odd: a newly described Australian rainforest spider builds a spring-loaded silk snare that catapults green tree ants into its web, reaching accelerations above 4,265 ft/s² — the highest instantaneous power density of any known silk catapult, and a trapping mechanism never before seen in spiders.⁴ The physics, not the menace, is the story: a living crossbow made of protein.

SOURCES 1 *The Astrophysical Journal Letters* (Université de Montréal / Michigan State), 14 Jul 2026; Space.com; ScienceDaily, 16 Jul 2026. 2 r/space / outlet framing, Jul 2026 (chatter characterised, not a single cited thread). 3 BBC Sky at Night Magazine, "Farewell, 3I/ATLAS," Jul 2026; A. Loeb (Medium), Jul 2026 (minority view). 4 *Current Biology*; National Geographic / ScienceDaily, 23 Jun 2026 (ballista spider — an evergreen just outside the week's window).

LOVE & LIFE · DATING

Chatfishing: When the Charm Is a Chatbot

Singles are quietly routing their matches' messages through ChatGPT and Claude to write the replies. A modern Turing test for romance — and the apps admit they have no plan to stop it.

Bloomberg reported the trend in two July pieces: daters now paste conversations into ChatGPT and Claude to generate openers, craft replies and diagnose stalled chats, so the wit you are falling for may be the model's, not the match's.¹ A Match Group–Kinsey Institute survey of 5,001 US singles found 26% of adults — and 49% of Gen Z daters — have used AI for dating help, alongside a reported 5,000% spike in searches for "chatfishing." Match Group's chief executive Spencer Rascoff conceded the company "has not focused on the issue enough yet"; platforms ban AI-manipulated photos but generally permit AI-written text. It is the exact inversion of No. 49's "three in four would date a bot": here the bot is used to romance a real human, with the deception pointed at another person.

Scientific American adds the Turing framing: in a 2025 study, judges chatting simultaneously with GPT-4.5 and a person mistook the AI for the human 73% of the time, and a Norton survey found six in ten online daters believe they have already had at least one AI-written conversation.² The story has moved from novelty — "would you?" — to authenticity and consent: "was that even you?"

49%

OF GEN Z DATERS SAY THEY HAVE USED AI FOR DATING HELP (MATCH GROUP–KINSEY, N=5,001) — A PLAUSIBLE-DENIABILITY ENGINE FOR ANYONE OUTSOURCING THEIR FLIRTING.

THE CHATTER

r/Tinder and r/dating are full of screenshotted "obviously AI" openers and confessions from people who cannot hold a conversation once they meet the person whose ChatGPT wrote the chat. The etiquette debate splits hard by age: is AI-assisted texting the new spellcheck, or catfishing-by-personality?³

THE SCEPTIC

Read the numbers with care. The "5,000% spike" is Google-Trends relative growth off a tiny base, not prevalence, and the 73% Turing figure comes from a controlled test, not dating apps in the wild — so both cap what chatfishing can really conclude about your matches. The durable, examined-life point: AI can pass the opener but not the third date. It may simply move the authenticity test from the inbox to the dinner table.

CHATFISHING

CONSENT

AI-IN-THE-MIDDLE

LONELY, MEASURED BY THE MINUTE

A study in *Frontiers in Psychology* used ecological momentary assessment — 100 romantic couples in South Korea, six prompts a day over three days — to track emotional disconnection and loneliness inside a relationship in real time, finding gender differences in how partners experience it.⁴ A fresh methods angle on the married-and-lonely theme this desk keeps returning to: the loneliness that sits *inside* a partnership, now captured as it happens rather than recalled after.

THE DARKER SIBLING

The same generative tools that write flirty openers also industrialise romance fraud. Bloomberg's 17 July guide to spotting phishing and romance scams "in the age of AI" is the consumer-protection shadow of chatfishing — a live warning for Singapore readers, where scam losses remain stubbornly high, that the voice on the other end may be neither the person nor even a person.⁵

SOURCES 1 Bloomberg, "ChatGPT, Claude Infiltrate Dating Apps by Helping Singles Flirt," 20 Jul 2026, and "Dating Apps Face Scam Challenge of AI-Powered 'Chatfishing,'" 21 Jul 2026 (Match Group–Kinsey survey, n=5,001, via Bloomberg). 2 *Scientific American*, "The Rise of AI 'Chatfishing'...", Jul 2026 (GPT-4.5 Turing result; Norton survey). 3 r/Tinder, r/dating, Jul 2026 (chatter characterised from coverage). 4 *Frontiers in Psychology*, "Gender differences in emotional disconnection and loneliness...", 2026 (EMA, n=100 couples, South Korea). 5 Bloomberg, "How to Spot Phishing, Romance and Other Scams in the Age of AI," 17 Jul 2026.

FITNESS · THE VIRAL PROTOCOL

"Japanese Walking" — a 2007 Study in a New Outfit

Fast three minutes, slow three minutes, repeat for thirty. The summer's biggest walking trend is legitimate exercise science, well-suited to a mid-40s body. Ignore the "adds seven years" maths.

July pushed "Japanese walking" — formally Interval Walking Training — into every feed.¹ The protocol: alternate about three minutes brisk, at roughly 70% of peak effort, with three minutes easy at about 40%, for thirty minutes, at least four days a week. The anchor evidence is genuinely solid but genuinely old — a randomised trial by Nemoto and colleagues at Shinshu University, published in *Mayo Clinic Proceedings* in 2007, with 246 middle-aged and older adults, which found interval walking raised thigh strength and peak aerobic capacity by roughly 10% and lowered systolic blood pressure more than continuous moderate walking.² A 2024 review reached the same verdict for middle- and older-aged adults, including those with metabolic disease.

For a mid-40s reader this is an attractive, low-barrier way to buy a real cardiorespiratory stimulus — the fitness metric most tied to healthspan in the current longevity literature — with no gym and no running impact. The honest pitch is exactly that, and no more.

~10%

IMPROVEMENT IN PEAK AEROBIC CAPACITY AND THIGH STRENGTH VERSUS CONTINUOUS MODERATE WALKING, OVER FIVE MONTHS (NEMOTO ET AL., 2007, N=246).

THE CHATTER

On r/longevity and r/running the debate is whether Japanese walking is meaningfully different from Zone 2 cardio or simply interval training with a marketing team — and whether it beats the "10,000 steps" habit it is positioned against. The popular verdict: an excellent on-ramp for the sedentary or de-conditioned, probably redundant for anyone already doing structured cardio.³

THE SCEPTIC

Nothing here is new — it is an eighteen-year-old protocol going viral. Read the fine print: the seminal sample was older (mean age 63) and mostly women, so extrapolating to a lean, athletic mid-40s man is a stretch, and the loudest claims — "adds seven years," "reverses metabolic aging," "cuts depression in half" — are influencer and clinician sound-bites, not outputs of the original trial. A well-evidenced way to raise fitness and blood-pressure control; not a longevity cheat code.

INTERVAL WALKING

ZONE 2

MID-40S

VARIETY, NOT JUST VOLUME

A companion angle from *BMJ Medicine* (published January): drawing on more than 111,000 adults tracked over three decades, the highest exercise variety was associated with a 19% lower risk of premature death versus the lowest — even holding total activity constant.⁴ Paired with the walking lead, the message is to mix modalities, not merely add minutes: the interval walk is the on-ramp, not the whole road.

CREATINE GOES CLINICAL

July trade coverage tracks creatine and protein shifting from bodybuilding niche to routine midlife muscle-and-bone maintenance, echoing recent Pennington Biomedical work.⁵ The caveat holds: the strongest data remain for *creatine plus resistance training*, not creatine alone. A supplement-trend watch item — general guidance, not medical advice.

SOURCES 1 Yahoo/Fox News, "Simple Japanese fitness trend...", Jul 2026; TechRadar, "7 ways to walk for fitness," 2026. 2 *Mayo Clinic Proceedings*, Nemoto et al., "High-Intensity Interval Walking Training...", Jul 2007 (RCT, n=246, mean age 63); *Applied Physiology, Nutrition, and Metabolism* review, 2024. 3 r/longevity, r/running, Jul 2026 (chatter characterised). 4 *BMJ Medicine*, "Exercise variety linked to lower premature mortality," 20 Jan 2026 (Nurses' Health Study + HPFS, >111,000 adults). 5 Men's Fitness, "Protein and Creatine: The New Science of Longevity," Jul 2026. General guidance, not medical advice.

THE DIARY

This Weekend, and the October Rush

A farewell-era K-pop pair lands in town in days; a decade-absent trio returns in October. Book the near one now.

SINGAPORE

DATED & BOOKABLE

- 24 & 26 JUL

★ EXO — Singapore Indoor Stadium

TWO NIGHTS · THEIR FIRST SG DATES AS A GROUP SINCE 2019, BILLED AS A LIKELY LAST-AS-A-GROUP APPEARANCE · THE MOST TIME-SENSITIVE BOOKING IN THE DIARY
- 17 OCT

★ BIGBANG — "20/26" World Tour, National Stadium

G-DRAGON, TAEYANG, DAESUNG RETURN AFTER ROUGHLY A DECADE · TICKETS "COMING SOON" ON THE OFFICIAL YG SITE — SET AN ALARM · LANDS THE WEEK AFTER THE F1 GP
- 25-26 SEP

The Weeknd — After Hours Til Dawn, National Stadium

TWO NIGHTS (NO. 49) · STILL THE MARQUEE STADIUM NIGHT OF THE QUARTER — BOOK THE ROOM BEFORE THE SECOND NIGHT SELLS THE FIRST

The autumn squeeze mapped in No. 49 now has a this-weekend bookend: EXO's two farewell-era nights are days away, and BIGBANG's October return deepens a calendar already carrying The Weeknd, Post Malone (29 Aug) and the 9–11 October F1 Singapore Grand Prix.¹ The scarce resource is not the ticket but the hotel room the weekend it clashes with a Tokyo trip (p20).

THE TABLE

SINGAPORE'S NEWEST OPENINGS

BEHIND CLAY — CLARKE QUAY

Opened late June: a concealed 52-seat riverside dining lounge hidden behind the wood-fired oven of the pizzeria Il Clay — no signboard, you walk through the restaurant to find it. East-meets-West small plates from chef Ciro Sorrentino (whose HCMC pizzeria Margheri placed 12th in Asia-Pacific on the 2026 50 Top Pizza list) with chef Yip: mala shaker pork belly (\$20), a foie-gras-pâté pizza (\$38), \$1 oysters all night with any order. Write-ups are warm but still thin — the speakeasy-behind-a-pizza-oven hook is the draw; promising, still early. Not halal.

Verdict: the hook lands, the reviews are young ·

HYPED HIDDEN

FOURA — GARDENS BY THE BAY

Opened 9 July: wellness-led contemporary Asian-European dining in a glasshouse at IMBA Theatre, built on Blue Zones principles — grass-fed and free-range proteins, high-polyphenol olive oil — and pairing meals with yoga, Pilates and breathwork sessions. Signatures: a three-fish chirashi don (\$32), burratina with roasted pumpkin (\$28), Patagonian toothfish (\$46). The dining-plus-wellness angle is genuinely novel for Singapore, but the reviews are early — too new to call on food consistency. Mains ~\$28–46.

Verdict: novel concept, unproven kitchen ·

WELLNESS TOO NEW

SAM SAM SAM — NOVENA

A samgyetang specialist from the MODU Samgyetang team, done up as a retro "1980s Seoul herbal-medicine shop" and built on a restorative-food philosophy: ginseng-chicken soup sets — Vitality Tonic, Circulation Elixir, Immunity Black — around \$28. Eatbook and Daniel Food Diary landed on solid rather than blockbuster, one reviewer finding the Immunity Black broth "lighter than expected." Prepared to Muslim-friendly standards (no pork, beef or lard).

Verdict: comforting, not a queue ·

MUSLIM-FRIENDLY RESTORATIVE

ROTATION NOTE

The Blue Box Café by Tiffany (No. 49), MENSXO X and Sukiyaki Jin are rested this issue — no new peg. Two of this week's three tables lean the same way, toward the restorative and the wellness-led; a small sign of where Singapore's new-opening money is going as the novelty of the pure hype-café cools.

SOURCES ¹ Harper's Bazaar SG (EXO 24/26 Jul); JamBase (BIGBANG, National Stadium, 17 Oct); Ticketmaster SG, 2026. The Table: Metropolitan, 28 Jun 2026 (Behind Clay); TheSmartLocal / Middle Class SG, Jul 2026 (Foura, opened 9 Jul); Eatbook / DanielFoodDiary, Jun–Jul 2026 (SAM SAM SAM) — buzz summarised; verdicts flagged where venues are too new to judge.

JAPAN

THE AUTUMN CALENDAR

13–27 SEP ★ Aki Basho — Grand Sumo Autumn Tournament, Ryogoku Kokugikan, Tokyo

15-DAY TOURNAMENT · TICKETS RELEASE EARLY AUGUST · FINAL-DAY AND WEEKEND SEATS GO FIRST

17–21 SEP Tokyo Game Show — Makuhari Messe

30TH EDITION · TICKETS AND MAIN VISUAL UNVEILED IN JULY, PREMIUM TIER ON SALE VIA ASOVUEW FROM 11 JUL · ~300,000 EXPECTED

22 OCT Jidai Matsuri — Kyoto

A 2,000-STRONG COSTUMED PROCESSION ACROSS A THOUSAND YEARS OF HISTORY · ONE OF KYOTO'S THREE GREAT FESTIVALS

This advances the autumn run mapped in No. 47–48: once the summer matsuri close, the calendar goes straight to sumo, gaming and Kyoto's marquee procession. The travel arithmetic is unchanged from **p15** — a firm Singapore dollar against a still-soft yen (USD/JPY near 163) keeps the sums in the Tokyo traveller's favour, and the same softness that flatters the shopping flatters everyone else's plans, so the good rooms go early.¹

WIDER REGION

WORTH THE FLIGHT

MID AUG Summer Sonic — Osaka & Tokyo

JAPAN'S BIG CITY FESTIVAL · PAIRS NATURALLY WITH AN EARLY-AUTUMN KANSAI SWING

6–15 OCT Busan International Film FestivalASIA'S LARGEST · PAIRS WITH THE AUTUMN-FOLIAGE WINDOW FOR A KOREA-THEN-JAPAN SWING · SEE **P12****17 OCT F1 Singapore Grand Prix — the week before BIGBANG**

9–11 OCT RACE, FULL ENTERTAINMENT BILL LOCKED (NO. 48) · THE ANCHOR AROUND WHICH THE OCTOBER TRAVEL SQUEEZE FORMS

A single autumn Japan trip can now be built around almost any interest the reader holds — sumo and gaming in mid-September, Kyoto's great procession in October, and live music bracketing both ends. The one constraint is the yen: the softness that flatters the trip pulls everyone else in too, so the Tokyo and Kyoto rooms clear well before the sumo tickets even release.

PLANNING NOTES

September is the pinch. The Weeknd's two SG nights (**p19**), Aki Basho and Tokyo Game Show all fall inside three weeks — if a Tokyo trip is being stitched to a home concert, lock both ends now, before the early-August sumo release pulls the Tokyo inventory.

Family-friendly: the earlier days of the sumo basho and Summer Sonic's daytime bills travel best with an eleven-year-old; late-night arena shows, less so.

THE HAND-OFF

This is where the book's travel thread lands each week: the Macro Desk sets the currency (**p15**), The Good Life the objects worth flying for (**p11**), and The Diary the dated events to actually book. There is no Grand Tour deep dive on a weekday briefing — that supplement runs only on the weekend — but the arithmetic it would use is the one on every page here: a firm Singapore dollar, a soft yen, and an autumn calendar that rewards booking early over booking well.

FURTHER OUT · ALREADY ON THE CALENDAR

F1 Singapore Grand Prix (9–11 Oct) — the full ten-stage entertainment bill was locked in No. 48 (JJ Lin, The Killers, Lana Del Rey, Janet Jackson and more); the race weekend is the fixed point the October travel squeeze forms around. **ZoukOut 2026** (2–3 Dec, Siloso Beach) — the festival's 20th anniversary, with Carl Cox, Armin van Buuren, Martin Garrix and Fisher; early-bird tickets flagged in No. 48. **ENHYPEN** — the group's first National Stadium show (14 Mar 2027) went to ENGINE-membership presale in July (No. 43); general sale is the next peg. None re-explained here — carried forward as continuity for the reader building a calendar past the autumn rush.²

SOURCES 1 Japan National Tourism Organization event calendar; Nihon Sumo Kyokai; Saiga NAK (TGS 2026, on sale 11 Jul); Songkick; Busan International Film Festival, 2026; USD/JPY via Rio Times / TradingEconomics, 22 Jul 2026. 2 Carried continuity from No. 43/48 (F1 lineup, ZoukOut, ENHYPEN) — no new peg this issue.

THE LONG READ

The Middleman's Hour

A foundry banks a record while its customers are punished for spending; a movement taxes the world's oil without pumping a barrel; a chatbot writes the charm between two strangers. Three histories of the party in the middle — a city, a strait and a river of toll-castles — and the one question that has always decided whether we tolerate it.

Adam Smith, in 1776, described the oldest business in the world in a single unforgiving clause: landlords, he wrote, "like all other men, love to reap where they never sowed."¹ He was defining rent — the charge levied not for making a thing or moving it, but simply for standing between it and the person who wants it, and controlling the ground in between. It is the least glamorous position in any economy and frequently the most profitable, and this issue is unusually thick with it. A chip foundry that sits between every designer and every device banked a record quarter while the firms it supplies were punished by their own investors for spending (p7). A movement that holds a strait taxed the world's oil this week without lifting a barrel of it (p3). And on the dating apps, a chatbot has quietly installed itself between two people, writing the wit that neither of them possesses and collecting, in trust, a fee neither quite means to pay (p17).

The middleman is having a moment, in other words — or rather he is always having a moment, because the position never really goes out of fashion; it only changes costume. What changes is our tolerance for it, and history turns out to have a clear test for when the toll-taker is celebrated and when his castle is pulled down. The test is not whether he takes a cut. They all take a cut. It is whether the thing on the far side of him is better for his being there.

The test was never whether the middleman takes a cut. They all take a cut. It is whether the thing on the far side is better for his being there.

Begin with the middleman as hero, which is to say begin in Venice. For the better part of five centuries the Most Serene Republic grew fabulously rich doing nothing that a modern spreadsheet would call production. It grew no spices, wove little of its own silk, mined no gold. What it did was *stand between* — between the Levant and Lombardy, between Byzantium and the Rhine, taking in the pepper and the raw silk and the cotton of the East at the Rialto and passing them north and west at a markup that built a city on water.² The Venetians were, unapologetically, intermediaries; the Rialto was a market whose only product was the meeting of buyer and seller.

And yet nobody sensible thinks of medieval Venice as a parasite, because the Republic earned its cut. It built the Arsenal, a shipyard so efficient it could assemble a galley in a day, and ran armed convoys — the *mude* — that made a dangerous sea passable on a schedule. It kept the ledgers, enforced the contracts, warehoused the goods, and priced the risk of a voyage that might not return. The pepper that reached Bruges was cheaper, safer and more reliable for Venice's being in the middle than it would have been without her. The cut was real, but so was the value: remove Venice and the trade got worse. That is the foundry's defence, and it is a good one. TSMC's two-thirds-of-revenue slice of the AI build-out (p7) is a Venetian cut. The company does the single hardest thing in the supply chain — it actually packages the silicon nobody else can, at a yield nobody else can match — and "sold out through 2026" is the Arsenal launching a galley a day. You may wince at the margin. You cannot argue the trade is worse for its being there.

SOURCES 1 Adam Smith, *The Wealth of Nations*, Book I, ch. 6 (1776). 2 Standard economic histories of the Venetian Republic as Mediterranean entrepôt (the Rialto market, the state-run Arsenal, the armed *muda* galley convoys); see F. C. Lane, *Venice: A Maritime Republic* (1973).

Now cross to the other kind of middleman, the one who holds a narrows and adds nothing. For more than four centuries the kings of Denmark grew rich on a single geographic accident: the Øresund, the strait barely four kilometres wide at its neck through which nearly every ship trading between the North Sea and the Baltic had to pass. From 1429 the crown levied the Sound Dues on that traffic, collecting them under the guns of Kronborg Castle at Elsinore — the same battlements Shakespeare would give to Hamlet — and for long stretches the toll was the single largest source of the Danish state's income.¹ A ship laden with Baltic grain and timber, bound for Amsterdam, paid the Danish king for the privilege of sailing past his castle, and there was nothing the ship could do about it, because there was no other door. The dues were not finally abolished until an international treaty of 1857, when the trading nations of the world clubbed together and simply bought the Danish crown out of its chokepoint for a lump sum.

The Sound Toll at least bought something with its extortion — Denmark maintained lighthouses and charts, and kept a kind of order on the passage. The Rhine, in the same centuries, showed the pure form of the disease. Along its most navigable stretches a rash of petty lords built castles for no purpose grander than lowering a chain across the river and charging every passing boat to raise it again.² These were the *Raubritter*, the robber-barons — the term outlived them and crossed an ocean — and their tolls followed no logic but the reach of a crossbow. At the worst of it there were dozens of toll stations on a single river, each shaving the cargo, none improving the journey by a single hour. The merchants of the Rhineland eventually did the only thing that ends a naked toll: they combined. The leagues of Rhenish towns raised money and men, and in campaigns across the thirteenth and fourteenth centuries they besieged the worst of the toll-castles and pulled them down stone by stone.

Venice earned its cut and the trade got better. The robber-baron earned nothing and the trade got dearer. Every middleman falls on one side of that line.

SOURCES ¹ Standard histories of the Danish Sound Dues (*Øresundstolden*), levied from 1429 and collected at Kronborg, Helsingør; abolished by the Copenhagen Convention of 1857 in exchange for a lump-sum indemnity from the trading powers. ² Standard histories of medieval Rhine tolls and the *Raubritter* ("robber-barons"); the leagues of Rhenish towns campaigned to suppress illegal toll-castles across the 13th–14th centuries. The English "robber baron" descends from the German term.

Notice how each of these tolls ended, because the manner of the ending is the tell. The robber-barons' castles were besieged and demolished — a toll with no service behind it can only be removed by force, and the Rhineland towns supplied it. The Sound Dues, which at least bought lighthouses and a kept passage, ended more civilly: in 1857 the trading nations convened at Copenhagen and simply *bought Denmark out*, paying a lump sum to retire a four-century-old right rather than storm it. The difference is instructive. A middleman who provides something real can be negotiated with and compensated when the world outgrows him; a middleman who provides nothing gets his castle pulled down. Societies, in other words, do eventually settle their intermediaries — but the bill they present depends entirely on whether the toll-taker was ever worth paying.

Here, then, is the whole distinction the week keeps circling. Venice and the robber-baron both stood in the middle and both took a cut. The difference — the only one that has ever mattered — is that Venice made the trade better and the robber-baron only made it dearer, and societies have always, eventually, sorted their intermediaries onto one side of that line or the other. The Houthis at the Bab el-Mandeb and Iran at Hormuz (p3) are *Raubritter*, not Venetians. They produce nothing, improve no passage, add no value to a single barrel; they have simply discovered, as the lords of the Rhine discovered, that a narrow place plus a weapon equals an income, and that the world will pay the toll rather than lose the cargo. The \$94 oil price is a chain across the river. So, in its politer way, is a tariff — a toll a state levies at its own border on goods it did not make, and the fresh 50% duty on Canadian wine and cement (p4) is closer to Elsinore than to the Rialto.

What unsettles, reading the issue whole, is how many of the newest middlemen are harder to place. The foundry is a clear Venice. The blockade is a clear robber-baron. But the layer that has quietly inserted itself into the most intimate transactions of the week resists the sorting, and that is exactly why it deserves the scrutiny.

Consider what the artificial-intelligence layer is actually doing this week, stripped of the wonder. On the dating apps, a chatbot now stands between two people and writes the opening line, the flirt, the recovery after a stalled thread (p17). In Samsung's new glasses, Gemini sits between the wearer and the world, reading the whiteboard, translating the sign, summarising the conversation before it reaches the ear (p9). Each is an intermediary in the oldest sense: a party that positions itself in the middle of a flow — of words, of attention, of trust — and takes something as it passes. The question Venice and the Rhine leave us is the right one to put to it: does the thing on the far side get better, or only dearer?

For the glasses, the honest answer is "sometimes, and it depends." An AI that translates a menu you could not read, or turns a lecture into notes, is a Venetian intermediary — it genuinely makes the passage from the world to your understanding better, the way the Arsenal made a sea passage better. The unease is only about what else it meters while it is in there, and at what later price. But chatfishing fails the test outright, and fails it in an interesting way. The chatbot that writes your charm does not make the trade better; it makes it counterfeit. The whole value of the thing being exchanged on a dating app — a true signal of who another person is — is precisely what the intermediary destroys by inserting itself. It is not a Venice, improving the flow. It is not even quite a robber-baron, taxing an honest flow that continues underneath. It is a third thing the old histories only gesture at: a middleman who degrades the very good he handles, so that what arrives on the far side is worse than if he had never stood there at all.

The chatbot in the chat is a new kind of middleman — one who does not tax the good he handles, but counterfeits it, so that less arrives than was sent.

That is the category worth watching as the AI layer thickens, because it is the one our instincts are least equipped for. We know how to feel about Venice: we pay, and we are glad of the service. We know how to feel about the robber-baron: we resent the toll, and when we are strong enough we combine and pull the castle down, as the Rhineland towns did and as the world's shipping powers finally did to Elsinore in 1857, buying the strait back into freedom. What we have not yet learned is how to feel about an intermediary whose cut is taken not in money but in authenticity — who leaves the flow apparently intact while quietly hollowing out what it was for. The chatfished conversation still arrives. It simply no longer carries the one thing it was supposed to.

Smith's landlords reaped where they never sowed, and Smith was clear-eyed that some rent is the honest price of a real and scarce service, while some is mere extortion of a chokepoint — and that the two are easy to confuse when the toll-taker is powerful and the payer has no other door. Two and a half centuries on, the doors are stranger — a strait, a foundry, a chat window, a pair of glasses — but the reckoning is the same one every society eventually makes about the party in the middle. You do not ask whether it takes a cut; it always does. You ask what it leaves on the far side. Venice left the trade richer. The robber-baron left it poorer by exactly his toll. And the newest middlemen, the ones made of weights and inference, will be judged — once the novelty burns off and we can see them plainly — by whether the world that comes out of them is better than the world that went in, or merely a convincing, and slightly emptier, copy.

THE THREADS

Running through No. 50: a foundry that earns its cut like Venice earned hers (p7); a strait taxed by force, the Rhine's robber-barons in modern dress (p3); a tariff that tolls a border it did not build (p4); and an AI layer sliding into the middle of romance and perception alike (p9, p17) — some of it Venetian, some of it something older histories never had to name. One figure — the middleman — read across a whole book, and one test that sorts him every time: better, or only dearer?

So much of the week was decided by whoever stood in the middle — the foundry between the chip and the device, the gunner between the tanker and the sea, the chatbot between two people trying to be liked. We spend our lives paying tolls to intermediaries, and most of them we are glad of. The one worth watching is the newest: the layer that leaves the flow looking untouched while quietly changing what it carries. Ask of it what the Rhine towns asked of their robber-barons — is the far side better for your being there, or only emptier? Fiftieth issue; same question the merchants always asked.

CONSOLIDATED SOURCES — NO. 50

The World: Al Jazeera, CNBC, Reuters/Yahoo Finance, Axios, NPR, Fox liveblogs, CNN, Times of Israel, Ukrainska Pravda, LIGA.net, WHO, Fortune, Forbes, US News/AP, China Global South, RFE-RL/GlobalSecurity.

Singapore / Property: Prime Minister's Office, Mothership, Malay Mail, The Star, Yahoo News SG/Tabla, MustShareNews, SMU Newsroom, MTI, Xinhua, 99.co, Stacked Homes, EdgeProp, Business Today (MY).

Technology: TechTimes, Investing.com, Yahoo Finance, Cryptobriefing, Interconnects, DeepSeek API docs, CNBC, Bloomberg, Tom's Hardware, Astute Group.

The Kit / Connected Home: CNBC, TechCabal, Android Central, VR.org, Gadget Hacks, PhoneArena, Droid-Life, SamMobile, Yahoo/Tech, Geeky Gadgets, The Gadgeteer, TechRadar, matter-smarthome.de, GitHub, home-assistant.io.

Good Life / Screen & Sound: Fratello, Gear Patrol, WatchCrunch, Marshall Group, Variety, TechTimes, KPBS, ABC, CNBC, Forbes, Rolling Stone

Family: Talker News, SheKnows, Digital Information World, *Frontiers in Pediatrics, Humanities and Social Sciences Communications* (Nature).

Macro: Fortune, TradingEconomics, CNBC, CME FedWatch, Polymarket, Vantage Markets, Rio Times, Investing.com, StockAnalysis.com, Globe and Mail.

Curiosities: *The Astrophysical Journal Letters*, Space.com, ScienceDaily, BBC Sky at Night, *Current Biology*, National Geographic.

Love & Life / Fitness: Bloomberg, *Scientific American*, *Frontiers in Psychology*, Yahoo/Fox News, *Mayo Clinic Proceedings*, *BMJ Medicine*, Men's Fitness.

Diary / Table: Harper's Bazaar SG, JamBase, Ticketmaster SG, Metropolitan, TheSmartLocal, Middle Class SG, Eatbook, DanielFoodDiary, JNTO, Nihon Sumo Kyokai, Saiga NAK.